demonetization exercise – the quantum of black money and counterfeit money that had been detected and destroyed and the promised benefits that would now accrue to them.

They were to be disappointed. No report card or numbers were shared, and other than a few token incentives,[32] no benefits either. The nation had suffered patiently for the 50 days requested by the Prime Minister, in eager anticipation of the benefits he had promised. The year ended on a sombre note as it started becoming clear to people that their pain, loss of income, disruptions of jobs, inconvenience and sacrifice had been in vain.

My Perspective

From a purely objective perspective, every patriotic Indian supported the objectives stated by the Prime Minister, namely, eliminating the scourge of black money and corruption, flushing out counterfeit notes, and choking terrorist funding.

Whether demonetization was the correct policy tool to achieve these objectives is debatable, as is the government's report card in achieving its stated objectives. These are discussed in later chapters.

But there can be no difference of opinion on the fact that in its implementation, the 2016 demonetization was an unmitigated disaster. On 13 November, the Prime Minister had stated in Goa that the move had been in the planning for 10 months. There is, therefore, no excuse for the shoddy implementation and enormous delays that took place in remonetizing the economy. To have subjected the Indian economy and 1.3 billion Indians to the liquidity crisis that followed the note ban was simply unforgiveable.

Irrespective of the policy merits or demerits of the move, the crushing effects of the liquidity crisis unleashed in November 2016 could have been avoided if adequate new notes had been printed prior to the announcement. Ten months was more than sufficient time to print an adequate quantity of ₹2,000 and ₹500 notes to replace the